

# Attention Is Infrastructure: Applying the a16z "Go-Direct" Playbook to Percona, Databricks/Lakebase, and EDB — and to Josef's PostgreSQL Job Search

## TL;DR

- The linked article (Linas Beliūnas's paid Substack "Attention Is the New Startup Infrastructure," June 29, 2026) repackages a16z's June 18, 2026 essay "New Media, One Year In": in an AI-saturated market where anyone can build, copy, and bundle faster, the scarcest input is **high-signal attention from the few people who can change a company's trajectory** — won by "going direct," being genuinely interesting, and treating narrative as compounding infrastructure. The framework is built for VC-backed consumer/AI founders, but its core mechanics (preferential attachment, developer mindshare, insider distribution, packaging) transfer strongly to open-source database infrastructure.
- Mapped to the three targets: **Databricks/Lakebase** is the purest embodiment of the playbook (it manufactured a whole *category* — "lakebase" — plus a ~\$1B Neon acquisition, an "agents create 80% of databases" narrative, and Postgres developer mindshare); **Percona** wins attention through anti-lock-in authenticity, community credibility (Percona Live, pg\_tde) and a bootstrapped-underdog story; **EDB** is running an explicit "sovereign AI" thought-leadership play (O'Reilly book, CEO predictions, NVIDIA GTC giveaway) but is the most exposed to the platform giants' narrative and distribution.
- For Josef: his profile — deep PostgreSQL internals, an open-source migration tool (credativ-pg-migrator), and an active conference-speaking/community presence — is *itself* attention infrastructure. The highest-leverage move is to position himself not just as a support engineer but as a **credible, "legibly interesting" public technical voice** who compounds each company's developer mindshare, while being clear-eyed that the playbook's fundraising/consumer-virality parts don't map to a bootstrapped services firm like Percona.

## Key Findings

**1. What the main article actually is.** "Attention Is the New Startup Infrastructure" is a paywalled deep-dive by Linas Beliūnas (a FinTech/AI newsletter with 395k+ subscribers). Only the intro is public; it explicitly builds on and summarizes Erik Torenberg's a16z essay. Its thesis: the two-decade playbook ("build a great product, find product-market fit, then layer distribution on top") is breaking because AI collapses the cost of building/copying/bundling, so "the product alone is no longer the moat." The new scarce input is "the founder's ability to make the right people understand the right thing, before the rest of the market catches up." It frames attention as "infrastructure": a category wedge, a proof stack, a distribution engine, and a measurement layer that compounds. The paid portion promises "8 founder moves," "5 shifts," a "minimum-viable attention system," and fintech/AI-specific narrative strategies — these are behind the paywall and cannot be verified verbatim.

**2. The source essay (a16z, "New Media, One Year In," June 18, 2026).** Authored by Erik Torenberg, Alex Danco, Elena Burger, and four colleagues. It defines a16z New Media as **"go-direct as a service"** with four motions: (1) in-house creative (video + editorial), (2) owned channels, (3) concierge "portco services" that coordinate launches, and (4) a network + software/AI layer for hiring and introductions. On distribution scale, the essay states the team offers "guaranteed reach across roughly one million X followers plus 250k newsletter subscribers," and notes it "amped up our podcast to ship 5x a week, our newsletter to ship 5x a week." Core doctrines:

- "To win you must go direct, and to go direct you must be interesting."** "Interesting" is an operating capability, not a personality trait.
- Startups are games of "preferential attachment"** — talent, customers, capital, and press must all *choose* to attach to you over thousands of credible alternatives.
- New Media is "not really a type of content" but "a type of packaging"** designed to surface what is already true and interesting about the founder/product.
- "Signal is what's important, and people confer signal, not brands."** Founders, researchers, and power users make an idea legible and credible.
- Own your distribution** ("table stakes"); quality *and* quantity compounding over time ("Anyone can make a nice car once. I'll be impressed when you can make a million cars.") (a16z)
- A linked companion essay by Anu Atluru, **"New Media Is Insider Media"** ("media for insiders, by insiders"), adds: "a small audience of the right people beats a massive audience of the wrong ones," "Audience Market Cap is the metric that matters," and "prestige is perceived taste legitimacy."

**3. The other Linas articles linked in the piece.** (a) **"The One-Person Unicorn"** (Feb 2026): argues a solo founder with the right AI "architecture" — he built 12 interlocking Claude "skills" covering the founder journey — can operate like a well-staffed startup; thesis is "AI outputs are only as good as the architecture and data behind them." (b) **"Anthropic Just Told AI Founders Exactly What to Build"** (May 2026): reads an Anthropic study on how people seek personal/emotional guidance from Claude as a product-market-fit map, cross-referenced with Anthropic's own job postings to find where founders face platform risk vs. open consumer space; cites Cal AI (\$40M revenue, acquired by MyFitnessPal) as proof. (Note: Anthropic's most closely related published research is "How People Use Claude for Support, Advice, and Companionship," which found affective/companionship use is a small share of interactions — 2.9% affective, under 0.5% companionship/roleplay — so Linas's framing of the size of this opportunity should be treated as his interpretation rather than a verbatim

Anthropic statistic.) (c) The "top 100 AI/tech VC investors" list. All three share the newsletter's meta-thesis: in the AI age, the binding constraint is no longer *building* but *knowing what to build and getting the right people to notice*. (Substack) (Substack)

**4. Domain caveat.** The article's native habitat is **VC-backed consumer fintech and AI startups** whose success is measured in launches, waitlists, viral timelines, term sheets, and hiring pipelines. Database infrastructure companies — especially a bootstrapped services firm — operate on longer trust cycles, technical proof, and reference customers. The transferable core is: **developer mindshare and community trust are the "preferential attachment" currency of infrastructure**, and technical credibility is packaged and distributed, not just produced.

## Details: Mapping the Playbook to Each Company

### The macro backdrop that makes this analysis coherent

PostgreSQL is now the gravitational center of the database world. In the 2025 Stack Overflow Developer Survey (released Dec 29, 2025; 49,000+ respondents across 177 countries), PostgreSQL is the most-used database at 55.6% — up from 48.7% in 2024, the largest single-year jump in its history — opening a ~15-point gap over MySQL (40.5%) and reaching 58.2% among professional developers; it is also the most-admired (65%) and most-desired (46%) database. This is "preferential attachment" already won at the *ecosystem* level — every one of Josef's target employers is, in effect, competing to convert Postgres's community mindshare into revenue. The three biggest data platforms all shipped Postgres-flavored databases in ~12 months: Databricks Lakebase (Neon, GA Feb 3, 2026), Snowflake Postgres (Crunchy Data, \$250M), and Azure HorizonDB (preview). Databricks paid ~\$1B for Neon — justified with the statistic that AI agents, not humans, create the overwhelming majority of Neon databases.

### Databricks / Lakebase — the purest playbook execution

**Business model & positioning.** Databricks raised a \$10B Series J on Dec 17, 2024 at a \$62B valuation (led by Thrive Capital, co-led by a16z, DST Global, GIC, Insight, WCM — a 44% jump from its 2023 \$43B mark). Lakebase is its bid to "own the last mile of the data stack, the application layer." It is a serverless, Postgres-compatible OLTP database built on Neon's separated-compute/storage architecture, integrated with the lakehouse via Unity Catalog and Delta.

### How it embodies the playbook:

- **Category creation as the ultimate packaging move.** CEO Ali Ghodsi didn't call it "Databricks Postgres"; he coined a *category* — "lakebase" — explicitly echoing how "lakehouse" became one. This is the a16z "packaging, not content" doctrine applied to product marketing. Ghodsi: "we're creating a new category in the database market."
- **Owned narrative + proof stack.** The "\$100B-plus OLTP market built on decades-old architecture," "OLTP databases have not fundamentally changed since the 90s," and the agent-provisioning statistics form a compounding proof stack that surfaces what's genuinely novel (agentic provisioning, branching) — textbook "surface what is already true and interesting." Ghodsi framed the acquisition rationale (May 14, 2025): "The era of AI-native, agent-driven applications is reshaping what a database must do. Neon proves it: four out of every five databases on their platform are spun up by code, not humans." Databricks' Feb 2026 "State of AI Agents" report extended the claim: agents "now create 80% of databases and 97% of test and development environments on the platform."
- **Distribution via developer/agent mindshare.** Databricks leans on the fact that "all frontier LLMs have been trained on the vast amount of public information about the Postgres ecosystem," so agents are effectively "experts" in Postgres. Postgres's open-source mindshare is the distribution engine.
- **Preferential attachment via a launch machine.** Public preview → GA on a tight timeline with launch partners (Fivetran, dbt) is exactly the coordinated-launch motion the a16z essay describes.

**Where it's vulnerable (per the playbook's own logic).** Independent voices note the attention is partly narrative ahead of adoption: analyst Sanjeev Mohan and others question whether enterprises are actually asking for agents yet. The "openness" claim has an asterisk — as one widely-shared engineering post ("Snowflake Postgres, Lakebase, HorizonDB: Picking the Lock-In You Want") argues, all three platform-Postgres products are "wire-compatible with Postgres [but] none of them is Postgres in the sense that matters to you"; deep Unity Catalog/Delta coupling creates "asymmetric" lock-in, and operational tooling (pgBackRest, Patroni, pg\_basebackup) "mostly [doesn't] apply." Scale-to-zero destroys session state, breaking migration tools and advisory locks — a real gap for exactly the kind of deep-internals work Josef does.

### Percona — attention through authenticity and community

**Business model & positioning (corrected/updated via primary research).** Percona is a ~20-year-old, fully bootstrapped, remote-only (colleagues in 40+ countries), roughly 335-350-person open-source database services company. It has **never taken venture capital**; the company states it generates over \$100M in annual revenue (a company/PR figure, not audited — third-party aggregator estimates are lower and inconsistent). Revenue comes from support subscriptions, managed services/consulting, and PMM — not license fees. **Leadership update** Josef must get right: Peter Zaitsev stepped down as CEO in October 2022 (now "Founder," board member & advisor); after an interim period with COO Bennie Grant, Peter Farkas was appointed CEO on October 7, 2025. Percona's release (Raleigh, NC, Oct 7, 2025) quotes Farkas: "As a former Perconian, I'm honored to be returning to lead the company." Farkas was Percona's Director of Support (2011-2016) and co-founder/CEO of FerretDB. Percona's brand voice is deliberately blunt: "Forever free from lock-in and other corporate BS." (Percona)

## How it fits the playbook:

- **Its entire GTM is "insider media" for the open-source database community.** Percona Live (revived, billed as "not a marketing stage, vendor showcase, or corporate slide deck parade"), heavy PGConf/KubeCon sponsorship, blog posts, forums, and the OurSQL Foundation are precisely Anu Atluru's "media for insiders, by insiders." Percona wins a *small audience of the right people* (DBAs, SREs, platform engineers) rather than mass reach. (Peter Zaitsev)
- **"Interesting" = credible and contrarian.** Farkas's "unshittification" framing and the anti-rug-pull stance (contrasting with MongoDB/SSPL, Redis, and Elastic license changes) is a genuine narrative wedge. *pg\_tde* — "the first fully open source implementation of Transparent Data Encryption for PostgreSQL" — is a concrete proof point that surfaces something true and differentiating.
- **Signal from people, not brand.** Percona's named engineers (Umair Shahid on PostgreSQL, Sveta Smirnova on MySQL, Kai Wagner on PG development) are the credibility-conferring "characters." This is exactly where Josef fits.

**Where it's vulnerable.** Percona lacks the owned-channel *scale* and capital of the platform players; its distribution is community goodwill, which compounds slowly. It competes for attention against hyperscalers and \$1B acquisitions with a fraction of the megaphone. The playbook would say: Percona's moat is authenticity and taste (prestige), but it must keep manufacturing high-signal technical content "relentlessly" (quality *and* quantity) or be drowned out.

## EDB (EnterpriseDB) — the thought-leadership platform play

**Business model & positioning.** EDB is PE-owned (Great Hill Partners 2019; Bain Capital majority 2022), ~1,500 employees, one of the largest PostgreSQL contributors, with 1,500+ customers. It sells EDB Postgres AI (EDB PG AI): a unified transactional/analytical/AI platform pitched around "**sovereign AI**" and up to 99.999% availability. CEO Kevin Dallas (ex-Microsoft, ex-Wind River).

## How it fits the playbook:

- **Explicit go-direct thought leadership.** The O'Reilly book *Building a Data and AI Platform with PostgreSQL* (with a hard copy handed to every one of the 25,000 NVIDIA GTC 2026 attendees), CEO "26 Predictions for 2026," and the "Sovereignty Matters" research are all "owned narrative + packaging" moves — building a category ("sovereign data platform") the way Databricks built "lakebase."
- **Proof stack via named customers** (MNTN, Waystar, NTT East) and quantified claims (up to 5x higher ROI; "only 13% achieving AI success at scale"). This is the a16z "measurable business impact" framing.

**Where it's vulnerable.** EDB's "sovereign AI" narrative is fighting for the same attention as Databricks/Snowflake/Microsoft — players with far larger owned channels and developer mindshare. Its message is enterprise/CxO-directed (outsider media) rather than developer-insider media, which the playbook argues is the *less* durable side of the divide. And it competes for Postgres mindshare against a Databricks that now literally owns the Neon developer brand.

## Recommendations: Josef's Job-Search Playbook

**Stage 1 — Reframe your own profile as "attention infrastructure" (do this week, applies to all three).** Your credativ-pg-migrator tool, conference talks, and technical authoring are not just credentials — under this playbook they are *distribution and signal*. Every employer here competes on developer mindshare; you arrive already carrying some. Rewrite your CV/cover-letter top line accordingly: "PostgreSQL internals specialist and open-source builder/speaker who compounds developer trust." Benchmark that would change emphasis: if a role is pure back-office L3 support with no external-facing component, downweight the community angle and lead with internals + SLA depth.

## Stage 2 — Tailor the pitch per company:

- **Percona (Senior PostgreSQL Database Engineer, EMEA remote — your live application).** This is the strongest fit for your whole profile. The JD explicitly values C/C++/Go internals knowledge, and the role includes "authoring new blog posts... answering questions on our forum, creating knowledge-base articles" — i.e., they are literally hiring you to *produce insider media*. Talking points: (1) map credativ-pg-migrator to Percona's migration-services growth and its anti-Oracle/anti-lock-in narrative; (2) cite *pg\_tde* and offer to contribute/evangelize; (3) note your PGConf.de/EU/Asia speaking as ready-made "signal." **Get the leadership facts right in interview: CEO is Peter Farkas (since Oct 2025), Zaitsev is Founder/advisor — referencing Zaitsev as CEO would signal you're not current.** Ask: "How do you measure the ROI of community/content work for support engineers?" and "Where does credativ-pg-migrator-style tooling fit — do you build services around it, or productize?"
- **EDB.** Lead with your migration expertise (EDB's Oracle-compatibility heritage and Oracle→Postgres migration business is central) and your contributor/community credibility that reinforces their "largest Postgres contributor" positioning. Offer to be a named technical voice for their sovereign-AI content engine. Ask how they intend to defend Postgres developer mindshare now that Databricks owns Neon.
- **Databricks / Lakebase.** Your deepest differentiator here is precisely the *gap* the playbook narrative glosses over: serverless/scale-to-zero breaks classic Postgres operational tooling, session state, advisory locks, and migration flows. Position yourself as someone who can make Lakebase real for demanding OLTP and for migrations *into* it — turning marketing claims into production reality. Ask how they

reconcile "open" messaging with Unity Catalog/Delta coupling, and where heterogeneous-migration tooling fits their agent-first roadmap.

**Stage 3 — Build a small proof stack before/between interviews.** Publish 1–3 sharp technical pieces (e.g., "Migrating Sybase/Informix to Postgres: what actually breaks," or "Running migration tooling against scale-to-zero Postgres"). This is the "packaging, not content" move: surface what's already true about your expertise, aimed at the *insider* audience of hiring managers and Postgres committers. Benchmark to escalate: if a post earns engagement from Postgres-community insiders, lean harder into the public-voice positioning in negotiations (it raises your "audience market cap").

**Thresholds that should change your strategy:** If you want maximum use of your internals + tooling + speaking combined, Percona is the best-aligned and should be your lead. If compensation, equity upside, and AI-frontier exposure dominate, Databricks ranks highest but fits your profile least cleanly (biggest reframing required). If you want to stay closest to the traditional enterprise-Postgres/migration world with a large contributor org, EDB is the middle path.

### Caveats

- **Paywall limits.** The specific "8 moves / 5 shifts / minimum-viable attention system" in the Linas article are behind a paywall and could not be verified verbatim; this analysis relies on the public intro plus the fully-readable a16z and Anu Atluru source essays it summarizes.
- **Domain transfer is partial.** The playbook is built for VC-backed consumer/AI founders chasing launches, virality, and term sheets. Its fundraising and consumer-growth mechanics do *not* map to Percona (bootstrapped, services-led) and only partly to enterprise infrastructure generally. The durable, transferable core is developer mindshare, insider distribution, preferential attachment, and packaging.
- **Forward-looking/promotional claims flagged.** The "agents create 80% of databases," EDB's "5x ROI," Databricks' category claims, and vendor lock-in assessments are largely vendor-sourced or analyst opinion; some analysts (e.g., Sanjeev Mohan) explicitly caution that agentic demand is running ahead of real customer requirements. Percona's "\$100M+ revenue" is a company/PR figure, not audited. Linas's read of the Anthropic personal-guidance study is his interpretation, not a verbatim Anthropic market-size claim.
- **Fast-moving facts.** Leadership, product GA status, and the competitive Postgres-platform landscape are shifting quickly as of mid-2026; verify current specifics (especially Lakebase feature/region status and any Percona role details) at interview time.